

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 250

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Section Title(S)

A SPEAKING AVOIDANCE • AVOIDANCE OF ASKING FOR FOOD • AVOIDANCE OF ENTERING SHELTERS

AVOIDANCE OF ENTERING SHELTERS

People who “respect” each other also avoid entering each other's shelters. A son's wife or daughter's husband would strictly avoid entering the shelter of his or her parents-in-law. A brother and sister, we were told, must be equally strict in this practice after they are married and have built shelters of their own. These remarks of informants imply that people in other relationships need not take this avoidance very seriously—and no wonder. If the shelter is supposed to symbolize a place in which to find privacy, in which one would be hidden, or a place for sexual activities, it is the merest token of a symbol. As often as not the shelter is not there at all. If it is, it may be half blown away by the wind. When fully constructed it is a half-hemisphere in shape, only about five feet long and three feet deep, with the whole interior space open to view. The !Kung do not sleep in their shelters nor live in them by day. They sleep and live by their fires. Still, this avoidance indicates that the !Kung do hold shelters as a symbol for demonstrating reserved behavior.

[342
Dwellings](#)
[513
Sleeping](#)
[576
Etiquette](#)

AVOIDANCE OF ASKING FOR FOOD

Reserved behavior requires that people who practice it refrain from asking each other directly and overtly for food. They give food to each other and receive it from each other as freely as do people who have the joking relationship, but apparently asking for food directly implies too much intimacy.

[261
Gratification And
Control Of Hunger](#)

A SPEAKING AVOIDANCE

This avoidance differs from the others discussed as part of reserved behavior in that it is required only in the relationships of parents with their offspring's spouses.

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

For the first few years after the marriage of a son or daughter, the parents and the son's wife or daughter's husband must avoid speaking directly to each other. When three children have been born to the son or daughter, or enough time has elapsed for three children to have been  251 born, the avoidance is eased and these affines may speak—not every day, we were told, but every third day or so. They should speak only about things that are necessary to discuss. They never are free to exchange gossip or huddle together in long intimate talks.

606
Parents-In-Law And
Children-In-Law

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